

CEO SUCCESSION / BOARD BRIEF

CEO Succession Checklist

A board-ready checklist for running a deliberate CEO succession, from defining the future-state role to benchmarking internal contenders against the external market and planning the transition.

1. Define the future-state role

- Articulate the strategy the next CEO must deliver over the next 24 to 36 months.
- Translate strategy into the 4 to 6 leadership capabilities that matter most.
- Agree non-negotiables versus development areas with the full board.
- Document the role profile before evaluating any candidate.

2. Benchmark internal contenders

- Identify internal candidates and the readiness gap for each.
- Assess against the future-state profile, not the outgoing CEO.
- Define development plans and timelines for credible internal options.
- Decide how internal contenders are communicated with and retained.

3. Calibrate against the external market

- Commission a confidential external market map to pressure-test the slate.
- Compare internal readiness against external benchmarks objectively.
- Protect confidentiality and momentum throughout outreach.

4. Plan the transition

- Define the decision timeline, owners, and board checkpoints.
- Plan the announcement, stakeholder, and investor communications.
- Design a 100-day onboarding plan with explicit early wins.
- Establish how the board will measure the new CEO at 90 and 180 days.

5. Prepare for the unexpected

- Maintain an emergency succession plan and named interim leader.
- Refresh candidate assessments at least annually.
- Keep external search resources identified and on standby.

Working through this live? Talent Pathfinder partners advise boards, CEOs, and investors on the decisions in this brief. Request a confidential consultation at talentpathfinder.com/contact.